

Special Education Syllabus

2026-2027 School Year

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Welcome

This syllabus covers what students and families can expect from our work together this year, including a few policies I ask every family to know from the start. Please keep this for reference, and reach out anytime with questions.

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Attendance Expectations, AttenDANCE HOCO

Attendance is directly connected to how well a student can access instruction and support, so I track it closely throughout the year. To attend Homecoming, students need to meet the following attendance standard, which we call AttenDANCE HOCO:

1. No more than 10 tardies
2. No more than 5 partial absences (arriving more than 5 minutes late to a class)
3. No more than 3 single-period unexcused absences

I will keep an eye on these numbers throughout the fall and will reach out well before Homecoming if I have any concerns about a student's standing.

Missing and Late Work in Intervention Classes

Our intervention classes, including the Literacy Labs and other specialized instruction periods, are built differently from a typical elective or content class. Each session builds directly on the skill practiced the day before, so when a student misses a class, that missed step is genuinely hard to recreate through makeup work alone. Research on academic intervention consistently points to the same thing: students make the strongest gains when they attend consistently, because skill-based instruction depends on repetition and sequence in a way that a worksheet sent home afterward cannot fully replace.

Because of this, I am asking for your partnership in prioritizing daily attendance during these periods. Illness and emergencies happen, and those absences will always be excused without question. What I am asking is that, where possible, we work together to schedule appointments and other non-essential commitments outside of intervention time.

When a student does miss a session, I will always do what I can to help them catch up. I just want every family to understand that missing intervention time is one of the hardest things to

make up, and that consistent attendance is one of the most effective things we can do together to support your student's growth.

Cell Phone Policy

Our cell phone policy is in full effect this year. Phones are put away bell to bell, meaning from the start of class to the end of class, in every period.

Weekly Grade Checks

Students are expected to send home a weekly grade check. This is a small routine with a big purpose. Checking in on grades every week helps students build the executive functioning skills they will need long after high school, including planning ahead, tracking their own progress, and knowing when to ask for help.

Staying in the Loop, Email Communication

If you or your student emails a teacher, counselor, or administrator about something related to their IEP, services, or general progress, please cc me on that email. This helps me stay informed and step in with support wherever it is needed, rather than hearing about a concern after the fact.

The Warrior Room

The Warrior Room is a space where students can go for additional support with assignments, tests, or quizzes. It is available every day during 5th- and 6th-period lunches, except on Tuesdays, when our team has a standing weekly meeting.

Math Lab, Learning Lab, Social Communications Learning Lab, and LANGUAGE!Live: What to Expect

Depending on your student's schedule, they may be enrolled in one or more support classes this year, such as Math Lab, Learning Lab, or a LANGUAGE!Live Literacy Lab. Here is a quick look at what happens in each one.

A quick note before the details: executive functioning skills, like planning, organization, task initiation, and self-monitoring, are woven into every lab and support class your student attends. Where Math Lab and the Literacy Labs build those skills alongside content-specific instruction, Learning Lab is where executive functioning is the explicit, primary focus, rather than a secondary support.

Math Lab

Math Lab provides students with targeted support aligned with their current general education math class. This includes preteaching upcoming concepts, reteaching material that needs reinforcement, guided practice, and dedicated time to work on current math assignments with support close at hand.

In Math Lab, we ask students to:

- Bring current math materials and any assignments in progress
- Engage in preteaching and reteaching activities, even when the content feels familiar
- Use guided practice time to build accuracy and confidence, not just finish work
- Communicate when a concept is not making sense, rather than moving on unsure

Learning Lab

Learning Lab is where we focus directly on executive functioning, the set of skills students use to plan their time, organize materials, start tasks, and monitor their own progress. Alongside that explicit skill instruction, students also use this time to stay current on assignments across their other classes.

In Learning Lab, we ask students to:

- Bring materials and a running list of assignments from all of their classes
- Participate in the organizational systems and planning routines we practice together
- Use the time to build habits, such as breaking down a task or planning backward from a due date, not only to finish work, but also
- Track progress using whatever tool works best for them, whether that is a planner, a checklist, or a digital system

Social Communications Learning Lab

This Learning Lab is designed for students identified as having autism spectrum disorder (ASD) who benefit from direct support in recognizing and building social communication skills. Students work on skills such as reading social cues, understanding another person's perspective, and navigating peer interactions in a supported, structured setting. This class is staffed collaboratively by two special education teachers, our speech-language pathologist, our school psychologist/social worker, and paraeducators, all of whom support instruction, so students have access to a well-rounded team throughout the class.

In the Social Communications Learning Lab, we ask students to:

- Participate actively in structured social skill practice, even when it feels outside their comfort zone
- Practice new skills in real interactions, not just in discussion
- Stay open to feedback from the team as a normal, expected part of learning
- Work on carrying skills practiced in the lab into other classes and settings

LANGUAGE!Live Literacy Lab (Year 1, 2, and Year 3)

If your student is enrolled in one of the LANGUAGE!Live Literacy Lab sections this year, here is a quick look at the program.

LANGUAGE!Live is a structured literacy program that blends foundational reading instruction, such as phonics, word study, and fluency, with grade-level work in vocabulary, comprehension, and writing. Students move through a mix of whole-group instruction, guided practice, and independent, computer-based lessons that adjust to their individual skill levels. Year 1 focuses on building foundational skills, while Year 3 continues that growth with more advanced text and writing work. The goal across both levels is the same: helping students become more confident, capable readers and writers.

Here is what we ask of students in the Literacy Lab:

- Come to class ready to participate in both whole-group and independent work time
- Bring required materials each day, including the LANGUAGE!Live workbook and headphones for computer-based lessons
- Give honest effort on the independent computer lessons, since these adjust based on how a student is doing
- Complete any assigned practice tied to that week's skill focus
- Ask for help when something is unclear, rather than skipping past it

Questions

Please reach out any time this year with questions or concerns. I am glad to be working alongside you and your student.